

Discourse Analysis (ENG523)

Introduction to Discourse Analysis:

Discourse analysis is the study of language in use, focusing on how people communicate and construct meaning through spoken or written texts. It examines not only individual sentences but also the broader context, social interactions, and cultural norms that shape communication. Discourse analysts explore various aspects, including language patterns, power dynamics, and the impact of context on meaning.

Two Strands of Discourse Analysis:

There are two main strands within discourse analysis:

- **Micro-level analysis:** This examines the structure of individual utterances, such as sentences or phrases. Researchers analyze linguistic features, syntax, and semantics to understand how meaning is conveyed.
- **Macro-level analysis:** This zooms out to consider larger patterns, such as entire conversations, narratives, or discourses. It looks at social contexts, power relations, and cultural norms that influence communication.

Discourse Markers and Conversation:

Discourse markers are words or phrases that help organize and manage conversations. They signal transitions, emphasize points, or express attitudes. Examples include "so," "right," "okay," and "anyway." These markers play a crucial role in maintaining smooth communication.

Discourse and Sociolinguistics:

Sociolinguistics investigates how language varies across different social groups, regions, and contexts. It explores questions like why people speak

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differently based on their background, identity, and social status. Sociolinguists analyze language use in real-world situations, considering both individual and societal factors.

Discourse and Speech Acts:

Speech acts refer to utterances that not only convey information but also perform actions. When someone says, "I would like the kimchi; could you please pass it to me?" they express a desire (locutionary act) and make a request (illocutionary act). Speech acts highlight the pragmatic functions of language beyond literal meaning.

Pragmatics and the Acquisition of Discourse:

Pragmatics explores how context influences language use. It includes understanding implicatures, indirect speech, and politeness. When children acquire language, they learn not only grammar but also pragmatic rules for effective communication.

Discourse: Gender, Racism, and Religion:

Discourse analysis sheds light on how language reflects and perpetuates social issues. Researchers examine gendered language, racist discourse, and religious narratives. By analyzing texts, they uncover hidden biases and power dynamics..

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Maha Malik

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